INTRODUCTION

During World War II, the Indian Army was the largest volunteer army ever raised, with a strength of 2.5 million. By 1944, a substantial part of it was being demobilized as the maintenance of such a large army was no longer considered necessary and by 1945 most wartime troops had been discharged and large number of units disbanded. Further demobilization took place after the war and by June 1947 the active strength stood at some 500,000.

With the partition in August 1947, the Army was divided between the newly independent dominions of India and Pakistan, with about 400,000 men and countrywide movable and immovable assets being shared under a complicated scheme supervised by a Supreme Headquarters. The partition of the Armed Forces was carried out in two stages, on a communal basis. During the first stage, Muslim-majority units were moved to Pakistan and likewise all non-Muslim-majority units stationed in Pakistan were moved to India. There was no entirely Muslim regiment, though, with every infantry and cavalry unit being a mix of different classes and religions. This resulted in detaching companies and squadrons from their parent regiment and allotting them to a new regiment based on its religious composition. In the second stage, units were ‘combed out’ based on voluntary transfer, but as the Muslim sub-units had already been allotted to Pakistan, processing individual options became difficult and a large number of Muslim personnel who had opted for India, continued to be allotted to Pakistan.